

AVOIDING AMBIGUITY

Dr. Mohd Hamid Raza

Assistant Professor

Department of English

GLA University

Ambiguity

- Ambiguity means that a word, phrase or sentence has at least two distinct meanings.
- In extremely informational communication it will cause barriers to understand. Sometimes it will cause divergence or dispute.
- The following examples are part of this kind of ambiguity.

A. “How is bread made?”

B. “I know that!” Alice cried eagerly, “You take some flour.”

A. “Where do you picked the flower?” the White Queen asked, “In a garden, or in the hedges?”

B. “Well, it isn’t picked at all.” Alice explained, “it’s ground.....”

A. “How many acres of ground?” said the White Queen.

During this conversation, the ambiguity is due to the two sets of homonyms: flower and flour and the meanings of ground.

For example, the verb “open” has many senses concerning unfolding, expanding, revealing, moving to an open position, making openings and so on.

For example, “bark” means both the noise a dog makes and the stuff on the outside of a tree.

For example, “sink” can be a noun describing a plumbing fixture or a verb meaning become submerged.

For example, the sentence “You are a lucky dog.” means you are very fortunate. In English, people like dogs and usually use ‘dog’ to signify the human being

For example, the “mad doctor” means the “psychiatrist” instead of a doctor who is mad. The “confidence man” means the “fraudulent person” instead of the man who has confidence.

Avoiding Ambiguity

- Are you looking to add clarity to your writing? If so, here are eight methods for correcting ambiguous expressions, as written by Norman Stageberg in “Ambiguity in College Writing: To a College Freshman.”

For example: You see, many hands make light work.

This sentence is ambiguous because of the words “light” and “work.” It is unclear whether light is a noun or adjective, and whether work is a noun or verb. So, readers are left to wonder whether the “light is working,” or the “work is light.”

Stageberg’s Eight Strategies:

1. Synonymy: Find a clear synonym to replace the ambiguous word.

The doctor made them *well*. ---> The doctor made them *skillfully*.

2. Expansion: Adding a word or two to the sentence can remove ambiguity.

He finished the race last Thursday. ---> He finished the race on last Thursday.

3. Rearrangement: Use the same elements in a different order.

They are chewing tobacco and garlic.

or

They are chewing garlic and tobacco.

- Since it's already known that chewing applies to tobacco, we are only uncertain as to whether the garlic is also chewable. So, by listing garlic first we identify that the “chewing” modifies both nouns.
- Otherwise, we can group the adjective, “chewing” with the noun “tobacco” after “garlic,” to clarify that the garlic is not chewable:

They are eating garlic and chewing tobacco.

4. Capitalization: Capital letters are sometimes useful to make sentences clear.

You should call your uncle George. ---> You should call your Uncle George.

- The first is ambiguous because it is unclear if the person calling the uncle is named George or if the uncle's name is George.

5. Punctuation: Commas, and other marks of punctuation, can be used to correct written ambiguity.

foreign study programs ---> foreign-study programs

- In the above example, we encounter ambiguity as the result of successive modifiers. For an in-depth explanation, see the heading “Successive Modifiers” at the end of this handout.

6. Spelling: Words that share the same spelling but different meaning in English are frequently the source for ambiguity in speech. However, spelling will rarely remove written ambiguity.

The governor went hunting bear last week.

7. Alternation of Context: In clear writing, the context restricts meaning of words and structures. Therefore, ambiguity can be remedied by making the context sufficiently restrictive. Include specific details to narrow the possible meanings of the ambiguous statement.

Successive Modifiers:

- When trying to avoid ambiguity in your writing, it is important to keep in mind that successive modifiers should always be considered an automatic danger signal.

- Successive modifiers are more than one adjective before a noun. The more modifiers (adjectives) you have before a noun, the more chance you have of ambiguity.

small business man (Is the business small, or the man?)

old car law (Is the law old, or the car?)

gray cat's eye (Is the cat gray, or the cat's eye?)



Thank
you